

Trump, seeking peace, faces two hard tests

He is struggling to get Russia and Ukraine, as well as Israel and Hamas, to negotiate.

By MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — After styling himself for decades as a dealmaker, President Trump is showing some receipts in his second term of ceasefires and peace agreements brokered on his watch. But the president faces extraordinary challenges in his latest push to negotiate ends to the world's two bloodiest conflicts.

Stakes could not be higher in Ukraine, where nearly a million Russian soldiers have been killed or wounded in pursuit of Vladimir Putin's war of conquest, according to independent analysts. Hundreds of thousands of Ukrainian soldiers add to the catastrophic casualty toll. Trump's struggle to get both sides to a negotiating table, let alone to secure a ceasefire, has grown into a fixation for Trump, prompting rare rebukes of Putin from the U.S. president.

And in the Gaza Strip, an alliance that has withstood scathing international criticism over Israel's conduct of its war against Hamas has begun to show strain. Trump still supports the fundamental mission of Israel's prime minister, Benjamin Netanyahu, to destroy the militant group and secure the release of Israeli hostages in its possession. But mounting evidence of mass starvation in Gaza has begun to fray the relationship, reportedly resulting in a shouting match in their most recent call.

Breakthroughs in the two conflicts have evaded Trump, despite his efforts to fashion himself into the "peacemaker-in-chief" and floating his own nomination for the Nobel Peace Prize.

In Turnberry, Scotland, last month, Trump claimed that six wars had been stopped or thwarted under his watch since he returned to office in January. "I'm averaging about a war a month," he said at the time.

He has, in fact, secured a string of tangible successes on the international stage, overseeing a peace agreement between the Democratic Republic of the Congo and Rwanda; hosting a peace ceremony between

[See [Peace](#), A4]



FLORENCE MIDDLETON For The Times

VISITORS interact with AI at the Exploratorium in San Francisco, where the tech has become inescapable.

San Francisco wonders how its AI gold rush will pan out

By QUEENIE WONG

On a sunny day in San Francisco, along the city's waterfront, families dived into the wacky world of artificial intelligence inside the Exploratorium museum.

Visitors made shadow puppets for AI to identify, used AI to generate songs, asked chatbots questions and faced off with AI in a game in which players tried to draw images that only humans would recognize. A giant robot hand moved around and people peered into a video game chip.

They jotted down their hopes and worries about AI on cards displayed in the museum. Hope: AI will cure cancer. Worry: People will rely on AI to the point they can't think for themselves.

"It sort of breaks down those guardrails, those big walls that people have put up around AI, and allows them to have a conversation with somebody else," said Doug Thistlewolf, who manages exhibit development at the Exploratorium.

Art. Office Space. Billboards. Protests. The AI craze has intensified in San Francisco, spreading through work and social life in what some have described as a new gold rush.

The AI boom, coupled with the election of new Mayor Daniel Lurie, has also infused the city with optimism — tinged with anxiety. Some worry about the city's high cost of living, and whether AI will replace workers as tech layoffs continue.

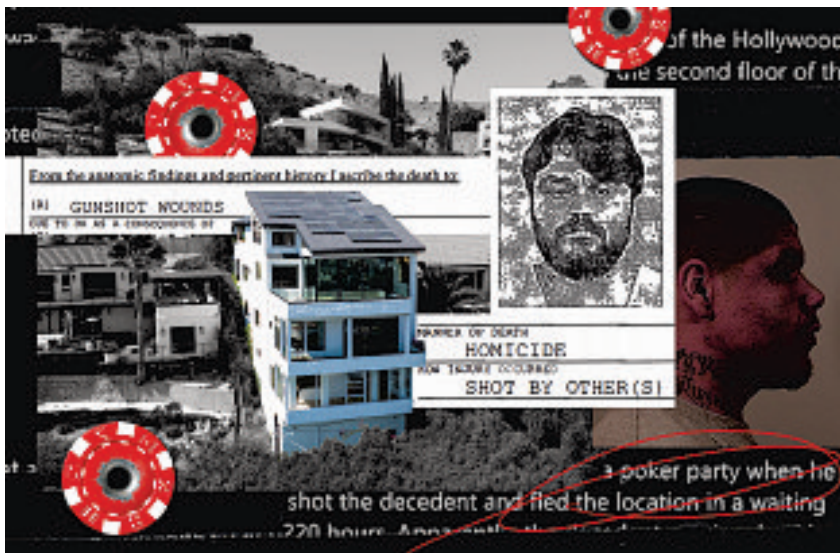
For years, Silicon Valley has been at the center of innovation with some of the world's valuable tech companies such as Meta, Google, Apple and Nvidia locating their massive headquarters south of San Francisco. AI's rise, though, has shone a bright spotlight on San Francisco, home to multibillion-dollar companies such as OpenAI, Scale AI, Anthropic, Perplexity and Databricks.

[See [AI](#), A16]

Mob, gangs, big stakes — and murder

Clandestine card games hosted at Southland mansions lead to Hollywood Hills execution

By Matthew Ormseth



Los Angeles Times photo illustration; Photographs by LUKE JOHNSON Los Angeles Times

Emil Lahaziel knew how to bluff.

On Instagram, he posed behind the wheel of a Rolls-Royce convertible. "Flying high," he wrote in the caption of a photograph taken on a private jet.

Never mind the seven-figure debt Lahaziel owed in his native Israel, according to a financial disclosure in a divorce case, or the admission to his wife that people were looking to kill him "as a result of some of the activities he did out of the country."

So it made sense that Lahaziel spent the last night of his life playing poker.

In the early hours of June 7, 2023, he went to a hillside mansion rented by a social media influencer. A valet parked cars as guests arrived on Fareholm Drive, which twists above Hollywood. Inside the three-story house, a chef prepared meals as men placed "high stakes" bets at the poker table, a detective testified.

At 2 a.m., Lahaziel, 39, walked out to meet someone he thought was a friend. The masked and hooded man shot Lahaziel in the face, leaving the Israeli national to die on the stairs of the sleek

[See [Cards](#), A10]

When fleeing fire is no longer an option

New research on sheltering in place could reshape how we prepare for disaster.

By NOAH HAGGERTY

Haylie Ross awoke to yelling and someone pounding on her dorm room door.

It was her resident assistant, telling her to grab what she needed and get to the library. A fire had erupted near Pepperdine University in the middle of the night.

Outside, there were chilling winds, helicopters roaring overhead, smoke everywhere and a glowing red sky.

Without time to evacuate, university officials instructed her and hundreds of other students to hunker down on campus. As Ross received a stream of texts

urging her to evacuate, school administrators, calm and collected, repeated the same phrase: "This is the safest place to be."

For many, the idea of hunkering down in a fire shelter for hours on end as flames enclose on all sides is hard to stomach.

But fires in California explode faster than ever due to a warming climate, flammable brush overtaking native species and more human-caused ignitions during high winds. Fires overtaking, in mere minutes, communities that take hours to evacuate are prompting a growing number of wildfire safety and emergency response experts to argue that fire refuge policies like Pepperdine's may be the only way to keep everyone in a vicious fire's path alive.

[See [Fire shelter](#), A8]

Nagasaki's plea, 80 years later

Survivors of the atomic attack remain resolute in hoping for a nuclear ban. **PERSPECTIVES, A2**

A welcome for Texas Democrats

Gov. Newsom greets protesting lawmakers as he discusses redistricting plans. **NATION, A6**

AI taking on Hollywood's role

As startups help turn film audiences into creators, where does that leave the industry? **ENTERTAINMENT, E6**

Weather

Partly sunny. L.A. Basin: 84/65. **B3**

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Photo illustration by JIM COOKE Los Angeles Times; Getty Images photo

FUTURE OF L.A.

A special section on Angelenos tapping their resilience to build a city for everyone is included in today's newspaper for print subscribers and available in the e-news-paper. **SECTION U**

UCLA research labs feel funding squeeze

President's grant suspensions lead to a scramble; academics fear a brain drain.

By DANIEL MILLER AND JAWEED KALEEM

Their medical research focuses on potentially life-saving breakthroughs in cancer treatment, and developing tools to more easily diagnose debilitating diseases. Their studies in mathematics could make online systems more robust and secure.

But as the academic year opens, the work of UCLA's professors in these and many other fields has been imperiled by the Trump administration's suspension of \$584 million in grant funding, which University of

California President James B. Milliken called a "death knell" to its transformative research.

The freeze came after a July 29 U.S. Department of Justice finding that the university had violated the civil rights of Jewish and Israeli students by providing an inadequate response to alleged antisemitism they faced after the Oct. 7, 2023, Hamas attack.

The fight over the funding stoppage intensified Friday after the Trump administration demanded that UCLA pay a \$1-billion fine, among other concessions, to resolve the accusations — and California Gov. Gavin Newsom said the state will sue, calling the proposal "extortion."

Amid heightened tensions in Westwood, thousands of university academics

[See [UCLA](#), A9]

ICE arrests higher in red states

California lags behind Texas and Florida, which cooperate more with federal officials.

By JENNY JARVIE AND GABRIELLE LAMARR LEMEE

Ever since federal immigration raids ramped up across California, triggering fierce protests that prompted President Trump to deploy troops to Los Angeles, the state has emerged as the symbolic battleground of the administration's deportation campaign.

But even as arrests soared, California was not the epicenter of Trump's anti-immigrant project.

In the first five months of Trump's second term, California lagged behind the staunchly red states of Texas and Florida in the total arrests. According to a Los Angeles Times analysis of federal Immigration and Customs Enforcement data from the Deportation Data Project, Texas reported 26,341 arrests — nearly a quarter of all ICE arrests nationally — followed by 12,982 in Florida and 8,460 in California.

Even in June, when masked federal immigration agents swept through L.A., jumping out of vehicles to snatch people from bus stops, car washes and parking lots, California saw 3,391 undocumented immigrants arrested — more than Florida, but still only about half as many as Texas.

When factoring in population, California drops to 27th in the nation, with 217 arrests per million residents — about a quarter of Texas' 864 arrests per million and less than half of a whole slew of states including Florida, Arkansas, Utah, Arizona, Louisiana, Oklahoma, Tennessee, Georgia, Virginia and Nevada.

The data, released after a Freedom of Information Act lawsuit against the government, excludes arrests made after June 26 and lacks identifying state details in 5% of cases. Nevertheless, it provides the most detailed look yet of national ICE operations.

Immigration experts say it is not surprising that California — home to the largest number of undocumented immigrants in the nation

[See [Immigration](#), A7]